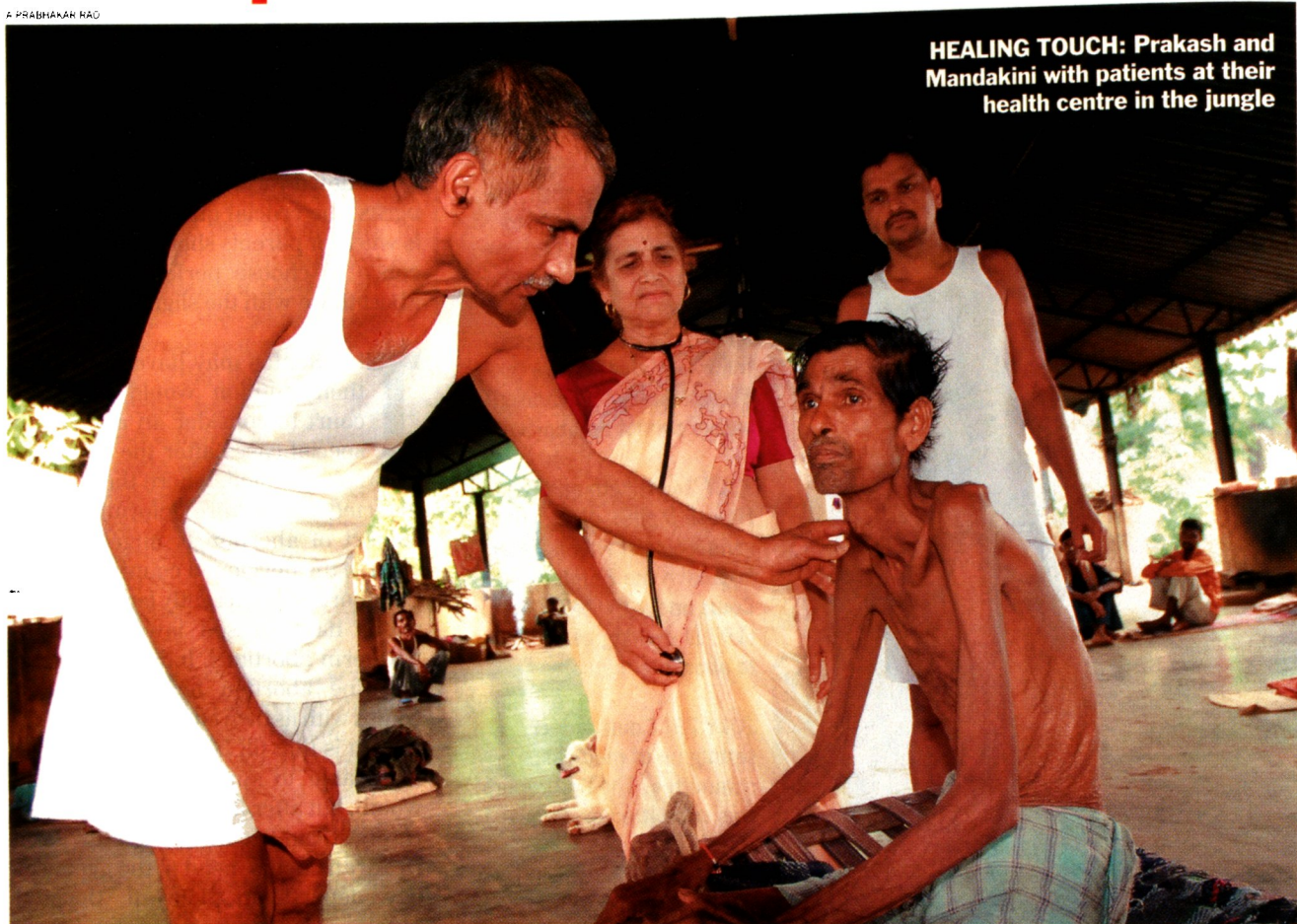


A PRABHAKAR RAO



HEALING TOUCH: Prakash and Mandakini with patients at their health centre in the jungle

CARRYING ON A LEGACY

Three decades after humanitarian Baba Amte won the Magsaysay Award, his son and daughter-in-law are jointly honoured for continuing to bring hope and healing to the poor and marginalised

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

For decades, they have lived in the shadow of a giant. Legendary Gandhian and humanitarian Baba Amte, who passed away earlier this year, received the prestigious Ramon Magsaysay Award in 1985 for his commitment to serve the poor and the deprived sections of the society. Last week, the same award was announced for his son and daughter-in-law, Prakash and Mandakini, for their commitment towards impoverished tribals in the remotest part of the country. Rarely has a prominent humanitarian award been given to both father and son, but in this case, it is richly deserved. Prakash Amte, 60,

and Mandakini, 62, are literally following in his father's footsteps. In 1971, Baba Amte trekked into the jungle to try and better the lives of Madia Gonds living in primitive conditions in the interiors of Gadchiroli district of Maharashtra. He set up the Lok Biradari Prakalp (brotherhood of the people project) in the Dandakaranya forest reserve; an area with low density of population. Prakash, a medical graduate like his wife, took up the father's dream project. They opened a clinic in a hut in 1973, providing healthcare in the nondescript village of Hemalkasa.

Initially, the Madia Gonds avoided the clinic even though they suffered badly from malaria, epilepsy, malnutrition and snake bites. Language and

lack of trust were the main barriers. To overcome them, Prakash learnt the distinct Gond dialect. He placed most of the hospital's facilities outside, beneath the trees in order to conform to tribal sensibilities. The Gonds were cut off from the outside world. They relied on primitive survival techniques, hunting and eating animals. Worse still, the tribal tract spread over 150 sq km of jungle also remained inaccessible for more than seven months in a year because of rains, absence of roads and communication links.

Undaunted, Prakash approached the Maharashtra Government to permit Lok Biradari Prakalp to put up a 50-bed hospital in the hope that tribals would bring their seriously sick